I) Inter-State Council

The article 263 of the Constitution says that the President of India can establish the Inter-State Council to serve public interests. There are three functions and duties assigned to the Inter-State Council

a) To enquire into and advise upon disputes among the States

b) To investigate and discuss the subjects that are common to the union and State Governments

c) To make recommendations to the President for better co-ordination on any particular subjects among the State Governments.

A number of councils have been created to promote cooperation on specific subjects in the past like the Central Council of Health, Transport Development Council, and Central Council of Local Self- Government.

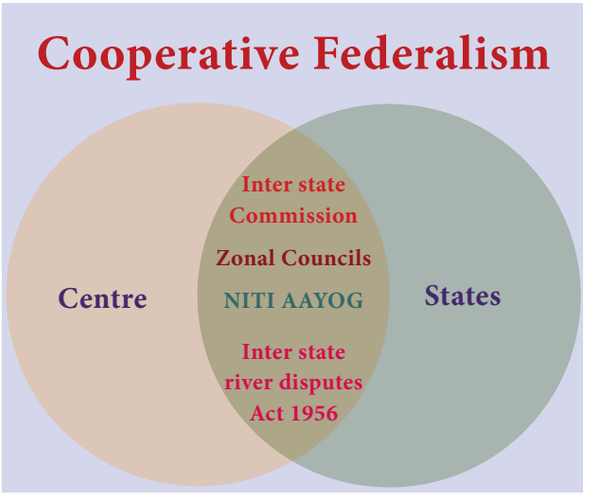
The holistic Inter-State Council was established in early nineties to deal with general cooperation among the units of Indian federal system on the recommendation of the Sarkaria Commission. The Prime Minister functions as the chairperson of the council. The Chief Ministers of all the States and Union Territories with Legislative Assemblies, six cabinet ministers of the Union Government, administrators of the Union Territories without Legislative Assemblies and Governors of States under President's Rule are its members. A Standing Committee consisting of the Union Home Minister, five other Cabinet Ministers and nine Chief Ministers also works as part of the Inter State Council to promote co-operation among the members of the federal system.

II) Statutory Bodies

There are certain bodies created through the statute of the parliament but not mentioned in the Constitution that function to promote cooperative federalism.

1. Zonal Councils

The Zonal Councils were established by the States Reorganization Act in 1956 to achieve cooperation and co-ordination among States. They were created in the backdrop of linguistic reorganization of India and the first Prime Minister of India Jawaharlal Nehru described their objective as to "develop the habit of co-operative working". Originally five Zonal Councils were created and later on in



1971 one more Zonal Council was established for the North Eastern States. They are

1. Northern Zonal Council

2. Southern Zonal Council

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